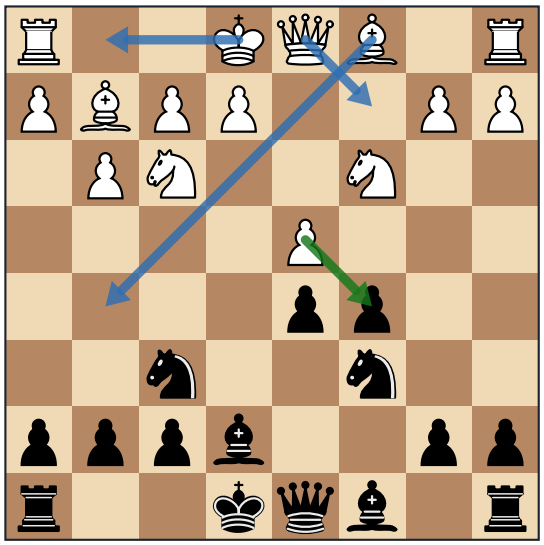
Tarrasch Defense

ECO D32-D34 | 27 named lines | Queen's Gambit / Slav family

In one sentence: The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Memory pattern: c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7

Key ideas

1. Challenge d5 with c4: if Black takes (QGA), White regains the pawn and gets center.
2. QGD: Black holds d5 with ...e6; the light bishop is the problem piece.
3. Slav: ...c6 keeps the light bishop free for ...Bf5.
4. Exchange Carlsbad: White plays the minority attack b4-b5; Black counters with ...Ne4 and ...f5.
5. Black's freeing moves are ...c5 and ...e5; White's are e4 and Qc2/Bd3 kingside play.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.35** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best: dxc5.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.
2. Where does my king go?	Both sides castle kingside; the king is rarely attacked early.
3. Best minor pieces?	White: Bg5/Bf4, Nc3/Nf3, Bd3, Rc1. Black: Nbd7, Bb7 or Bf5, Be7, Rc8.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... d5	Hold the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. c4	Attack d5. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
3... c5	Free the position. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4. cxd5	Exchange, minority attack.
4... exd5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
5. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
5... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
6. g3	Gains space on the wing.
6... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
7. Bg2	Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
7... Be7	Develops the bishop to e7.



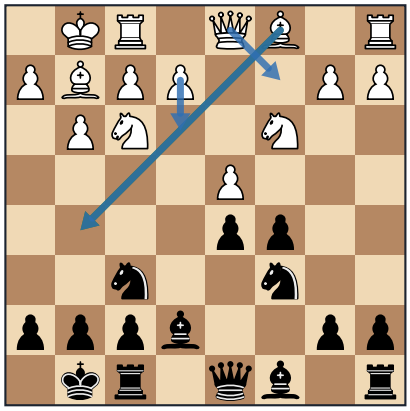
After 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6



After 6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.



Position after the line

Classical Variation D34 | 11 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O`

Stockfish: **+0.39** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bg5.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Advance Variation, Bogoljubow Variation, Carlsbad Variation, Chandler Variation

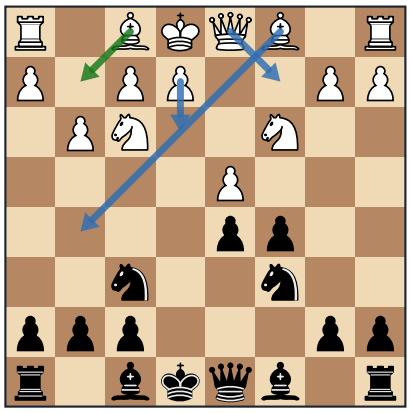


Position after the line

Symmetrical Variation D32 | 2 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.e3 Nf6 5.Nf3 Nc6`

Stockfish: **+0.14** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: cxd5.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)

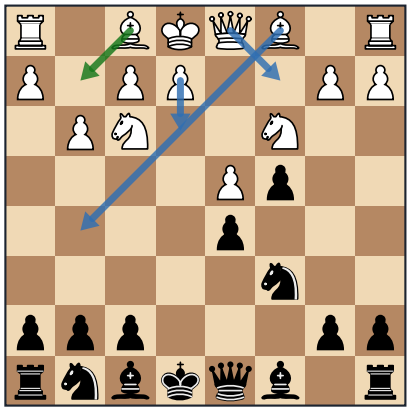


Position after the line

Prague Variation D33 | 2 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6`

Stockfish: **+0.30** (slightly better for White, depth 19). Best next move: Bg2.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Main Line

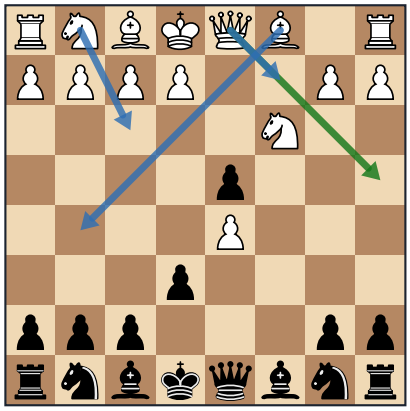


Position after the line

Swedish Variation D33 | 2 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 c4`

Stockfish: **+0.47** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Bg2.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Central Break

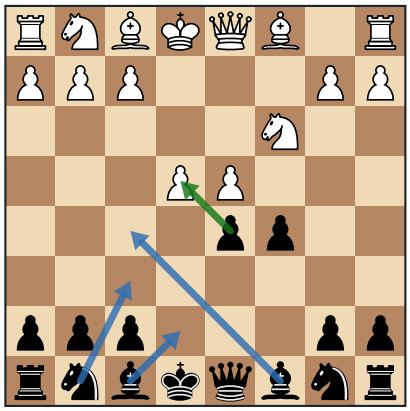


Position after the line

Schara Gambit D32 | 1 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 cxd4`

Stockfish: **+0.64** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Qa4+.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)



Position after the line

Marshall Gambit D32 | 1 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.e4`

Stockfish: **-0.03** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: dxe4.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)

Expert and coach view

Capablanca and Karpov played the Queen's Gambit Declined with great success.

What a coach would tell you

Know the three structures: Carlsbad (minority attack), IQP (attack vs blockade) and hanging pawns. Study the plans for each, then choose the QGD, Slav or QGA based on your style.

Why play it

The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Typical mistakes

• Taking on c4 without a plan to hold the pawn (...b5) or return it.

• Playing Bg5 too early or Nf3 too early without considering ...Ne4 or ...c5.

• Ignoring the minority attack and allowing a permanently weak c6 pawn.

Typical tactics and traps

• Elephant Trap: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Nbd7 5.cxd5 exd5 6.Nxd5? Nxd5! 7.Bxd8 Bb4+ and Black wins.

• Back-rank tactics when queens trade and the rooks are unconnected.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

QGD endings are usually balanced; Black's solid structure makes winning chances hard for White.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Tarrasch Defense (all lines)** D32
  `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5`
  - **Schara Gambit** D32
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 cxd4`
  - **Marshall Gambit** D32
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.e4`
  - **Two Knights Variation** D32
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3`
  - **Symmetrical Variation** D32
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.e3 Nf6 5.Nf3 Nc6`
  - **Rubinstein System** D33
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3`
  - **Prague Variation** D33
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6`
    - **Main Line** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 -> 7.Bg2 Be7`
  - **Swedish Variation** D33
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 c4`
    - **Central Break** D33
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 c4 -> 7.e4`
  - **Tarrasch Gambit** D32
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.dxc5 d4 6.Na4 b5`
  - **Grünfeld Gambit** D32
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.dxc5 d4 7.Na4 b5`
  - **Wagner Variation** D33
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Bg4`
  - **von Hennig Gambit** D32
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 cxd4 5.Qxd4 Nc6 6.Qd1 exd5 7.Qxd5 Be6`
  - **Classical Variation** D34
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O`
    - **Carlsbad Variation** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.Bg5`
    - **Advance Variation** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.Bg5 c4`
    - **Classical Tarrasch Gambit** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.dxc5 d4`
    - **Endgame Variation** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.Bg5 Be6`
    - **Réti Variation** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.dxc5 Bxc5 10.Na4`
    - **Bogoljubow Variation** D34
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.Nf3 d5 5.cxd5 exd5 6.g3 Nc6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O 9.Bg5 Be6 10.Rc1 c4`
    - **Petursson Variation** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.Bg5 cxd4 10.Nxd4 Re8`
    - **Main Line** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.Bg5 cxd4 10.Nxd4 h6 11.Be3 Re8`
    - **Spassky Variation** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.Bg5 cxd4 10.Nxd4 h6 11.Be3 Bg4`
    - **Chandler Variation** D34
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 Be7 8.O-O O-O -> 9.Bg5 cxd4 10.Nxd4 h6 11.Be3 R…`
  - **Dubov Tarrasch** D33
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 -> 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.g3 Nf6 7.Bg2 cxd4 8.Nxd4 Bc5`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 c5 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Nf3 Nc6
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> Bg5 -> e3
Black	d5 -> e6 -> Nf6 -> Be7 -> O-O

Three rules to remember

1. c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.

2. White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.

3. White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

Pawn structure in one line

c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.